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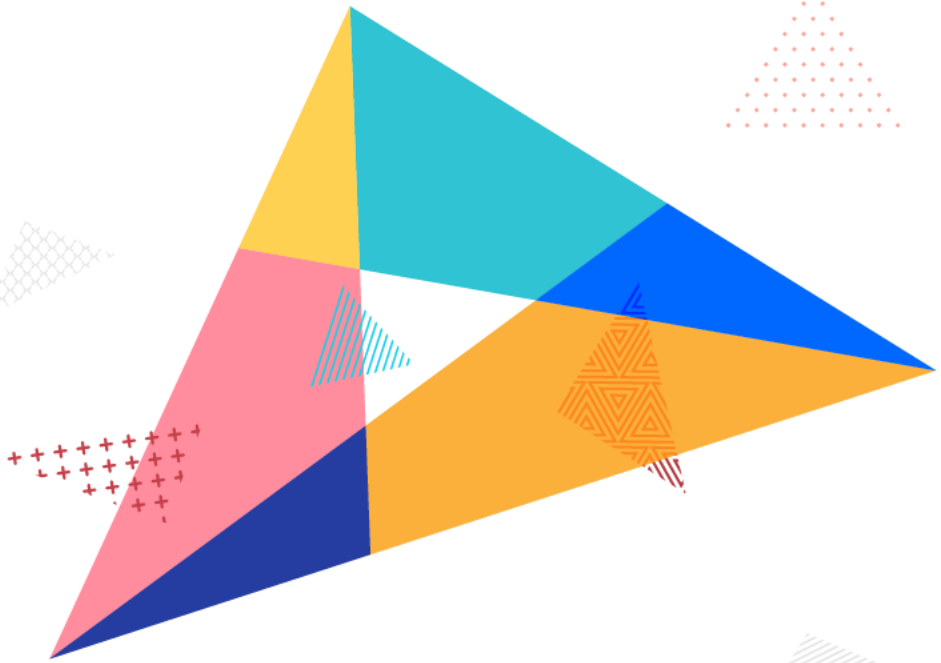
Zalo

me.grow

RMIT University Vietnam, Saigon South Campus

Building Trust & Open Communication In Teams

Dr Justin Xavier




BUILDING TRUST & OPEN COMMUNICATION IN TEAMS
TRUST
RESPECT
INCLUSION
COLLABORATION
GROWTH
Stronger Communication. Stronger Teams. Better Results.
WHAT BUILDS TRUST?
Keep Commitments
Be Consistent
Communicate Openly
Show Empathy
Give Credit
Follow Through
Great teams are built on trust and open communication.
INCLUSIVE LEADERSHIP
Commitment
Value diversity
Courage
Have difficult conversations
Curiosity
Ask questions & listen
Cultural Intelligence
Understand different perspectives
Collaboration
Drive inclusive solutions
Accountability
Hold self and others accountable
HOW CAN WE SUPPORT EACH OTHER?
TEAM ALPHA
Psychological Safety
Speak Up
Ask Questions
Share Ideas
Admit Mistakes
Learn Together
Psychological Safety
OUR TEAM NORMS
Listen Actively
Be Respectful
Challenge Ideas Not People
Assume Good Intent
Share the Air
Own & Learn



What we will cover

1. Why Trust Matters
2. Building Trust
3. Psychological Safety
4. Trust Equation
5. Inclusive Leadership
6. Application

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Ready for what's next

What we expect to learn



- Apply psychological safety principles
- Build trust through leadership behaviours and foster inclusive communication
- Create team norms that encourage speaking up and collaboration

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PART 1: Why TRUST Matters

Why TRUST Matters

TRUST is the foundation of high-performing teams.

- Trust is more than a positive workplace feeling -> critical organisational asset that shapes how people communicate, collaborate and perform.
- When trust is present, employees are more willing to:
  - ❑ Share ideas and raise concerns openly.
  - ❑ Collaborate across teams and functions.
  - ❑ Take initiative without waiting for direction.
  - ❑ Admit mistakes and learn from them.
  - ❑ Support organisational change and innovation.
- When trust is absent, employees are more likely to:
  - ❑ Remain silent during meetings.
  - ❑ Avoid difficult conversations.
  - ❑ Withhold information or feedback.
  - ❑ Focus on self-protection rather than team success.
  - ❑ Resist change and innovation.

Key Leadership Insight

- Managers influence trust every day through their behaviours, decisions and communication practices.
- Trust is not built through authority or position, but it is earned through consistent actions over time.

"Trust is the glue of life. It is the foundational principle that holds all relationships." Stephen M.R. Covey

Why TRUST Matters

Trust is NOT a soft skill -> Business performance driver

Business Cost of Low Trust *vs.* Business Benefits of High Trust

🔒 LOW TRUST

Employees remain silent even when they have concerns.

Common behaviours:

- Information is withheld or delayed
- Employees fear making mistakes
- Teams operate in silos
- Decisions are slower
- Blame is common
- Engagement declines
- People resist change

TRUST

Leadership behaviours shape trust

🚀 HIGH TRUST

Employees communicate openly and contribute ideas.

Common behaviours:

- Knowledge is shared freely
- Learning is encouraged
- Teams collaborate effectively
- Decisions are faster
- Accountability increases
- Engagement improves
- Innovation flourishes

"A team is not a group of people who work together. A team is a group of people who trust each other." Simon Sinek

Why TRUST Matters

TRUST in fast-growth organisations

Growth creates opportunities, but it also places pressure on communication, collaboration and trust.

- Why TRUST becomes more important as organisations grow:
  - ❑ Teams become larger and more geographically dispersed
  - ❑ New employees join without established relationships
  - ❑ Decision-making is pushed closer to the front line
  - ❑ Cross-functional collaboration becomes more important
  - ❑ Change occurs more frequently and at a faster pace

Managers cannot rely solely on process, hierarchy or direct supervision -> TRUST allows organisations to move quickly while remaining aligned.

The Leadership Challenge

- 🔒 Communication breakdowns
- 🔒 Information silos
- 🔒 Slower decision-making
- 🔒 Reduced collaboration
- 🔒 Resistance to change
- 🔒 Lower innovation

The Leadership Opportunity

- 🚀 Faster execution
- 🚀 Greater ownership
- 🚀 Better collaboration
- 🚀 Higher engagement
- 🚀 More innovation
- 🚀 Improved adaptability

PART 2: Building TRUST

TRUST Framework



TRUST Framework

BUILDING TRUST & OPEN COMMUNICATION IN TEAMS

TRUST IS BUILT THROUGH CONSISTENT LEADERSHIP BEHAVIOURS

T — TRANSPARENCY

Communicate openly and honestly. Share context behind decisions and acknowledge uncertainty when it exists.



- Explain decisions
- Share information early
- Clarify expectations
- Be honest about challenges

R — RELIABILITY

Trust grows when leaders consistently do what they say they will do.



- Keep commitments
- Follow through
- Meet deadlines
- Demonstrate accountability

U — UNDERSTANDING

Seek to understand before being understood. Listen deeply and empathetically.



- Listen actively
- Ask curious questions
- Show empathy
- Explore perspectives

S — SAFETY

Create an environment where people feel safe to speak up, challenge ideas and learn from mistakes.



- Invite feedback
- Encourage diverse views
- Respond respectfully
- Treat mistakes as learning opportunities

T — TEAM FIRST

Place collective success ahead of personal recognition and encourage collaboration across boundaries.



- Share credit
- Break down silos
- Support others
- Focus on shared goals

TRUST Framework

BUILDING TRUST & OPEN COMMUNICATION IN TEAMS

TRUST IS BUILT THROUGH CONSISTENT LEADERSHIP BEHAVIOURS

T — TRANSPARENCY

Communicate openly and honestly. Share context behind decisions and acknowledge uncertainty when it exists.



- Explain decisions
- Share information early
- Clarify expectations
- Be honest about challenges

Communicate clearly. Build confidence. Create trust.

R — RELIABILITY

Trust grows when leaders consistently do what they say they will do.



- Keep commitments
- Follow through
- Meet deadlines
- Demonstrate accountability

Keep commitments. Build credibility. Earn trust.

U — UNDERSTANDING

Seek to understand before being understood. Listen deeply and empathetically.



- Listen actively
- Ask curious questions
- Show empathy
- Explore perspectives

Listen deeply. Empathise. Understand others.

S — SAFETY

Create an environment where people feel safe to speak up, challenge ideas and learn from mistakes.



- Invite feedback
- Encourage diverse views
- Respond respectfully
- Treat mistakes as learning opportunities

Speak openly. Learn openly. Improve together.

T — TEAM FIRST

Place collective success ahead of personal recognition and encourage collaboration across boundaries.



- Share credit
- Break down silos
- Support others
- Focus on shared goals

Collaborate openly. Succeed together.

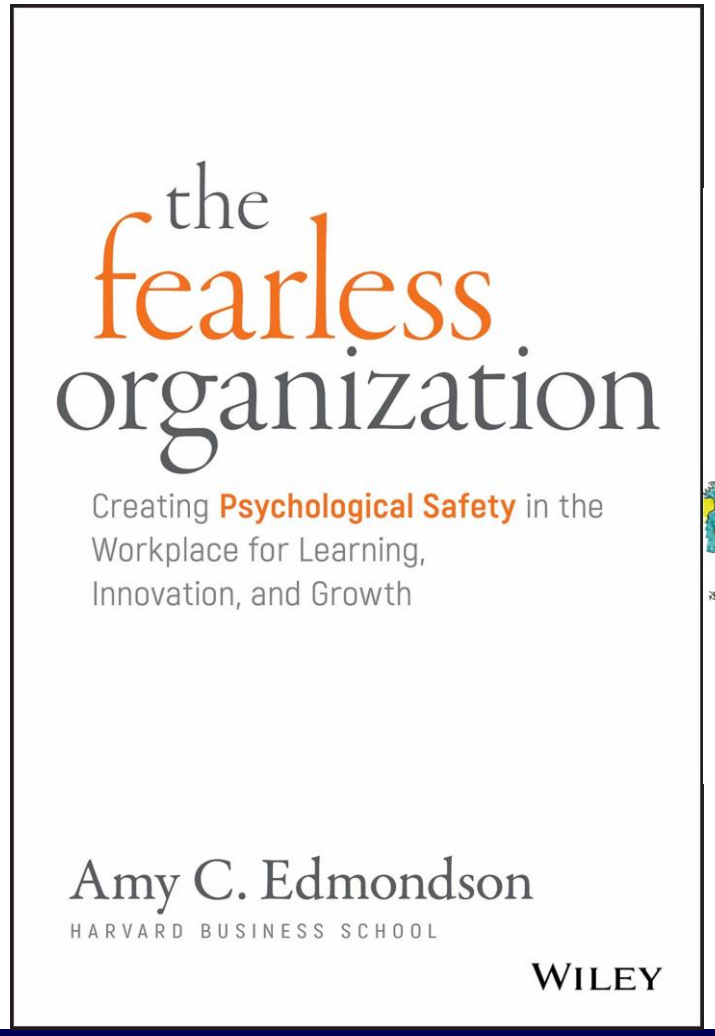
COMMUNICATION IMPROVES | **COLLABORATION STRENGTHENS** | **INNOVATION GROWS** | **PERFORMANCE ACCELERATES** | **PEOPLE THRIVE**

Trust is built through behaviours, strengthened through relationships, and reflected in performance.

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PART 3: Psychological Safety

Psychological Safety










THE HBR GUIDE:
What exactly is psychological safety?
Harvard Business Review



HOW psychological safety RELATES TO PERFORMANCE STANDARDS

AMY EDMONDSON

PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY (HIGH ↑ / LOW ↓)

COMFORT ZONE



People are open and collegial but not challenged. On teams, they fail to make major strides.

LEARNING ZONE



People collaborate and learn in the service of high performance, getting complex and innovative work done.

APATHY ZONE



People show up at work with their hearts and minds elsewhere; choosing self protection over exertion.

ANXIETY ZONE



People are reluctant to offer ideas, try new things, or ask for help, putting the work at risk.

LOW ← PERFORMANCE STANDARDS → HIGH

Sketchnote: Tanmay Vora, QAspire.com

www.amycedmondson.com

WHAT'S THE DIFF?

Trust and Psychological Safety

Psychological safety is the belief that your environment is safe for interpersonal risk-taking. It's similar, but slightly different from, trust.

TRUST

Will **YOU** give others the benefit of the doubt when you take a risk?



"Bob is probably going to freak out if I disagree with him."

PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY

Will **OTHERS** give you the benefit of the doubt when you take a risk?



"My team expects me to speak up. It's how we do things."

Sources: Edmondson, A. C. (2002). Managing the risk of learning: Psychological safety in work teams. Boston, MA: Division of Research, Harvard Business School. and Frazier, M. L., Fainshmidt, S., Klinger, R. L., Pezeshkan, A., & Vracheva, V. (2017). Psychological safety: A meta-analytic review and extension. Personnel Psychology, 70(1), 113-165.

wendyhirsch.com

PART 4: Trust Equation

How do people decide whether to Trust

The TRUST Equation

by David Maister

$$\text{TRUST} = \frac{\text{Credibility} + \text{Reliability} + \text{Intimacy}}{\text{Self-Orientation}}$$



UNDERSTANDING THE FOUR COMPONENTS OF TRUST

TRUST = (Credibility + Reliability + Intimacy) ÷ Self-Orientation

CREDIBILITY

Can I believe what you say?

- Expertise
- Knowledge
- Sound judgement
- Clear communication

Builds: Confidence

RELIABILITY

Can I depend on you?

- Keep commitments
- Follow through
- Consistency
- Accountability

Builds: Dependability

INTIMACY

Can I be honest with you?

- Listen actively
- Show empathy
- Build relationships
- Respect confidentiality

Builds: Connection

SELF-ORIENTATION

Who are you serving?

- Share credit
- Focus on others
- Humility
- Team success

Builds: Intentions

Trust grows when Credibility, Reliability and Intimacy increase.
Trust declines when Self-Orientation becomes the focus.

"Trust is earned in droplets and lost in buckets."
David Maister

Activity

To increase trust in my team, I will focus on improving:

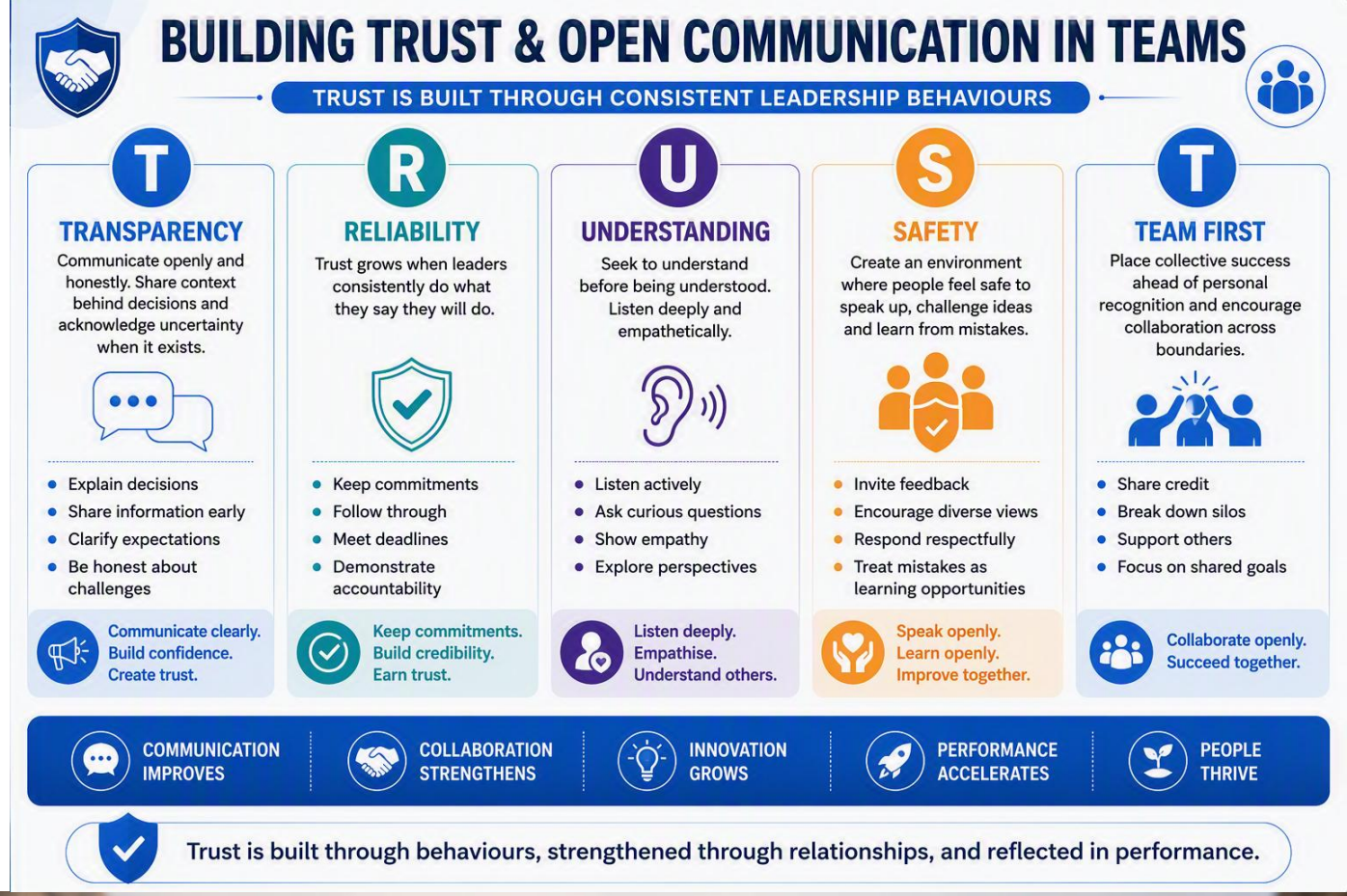
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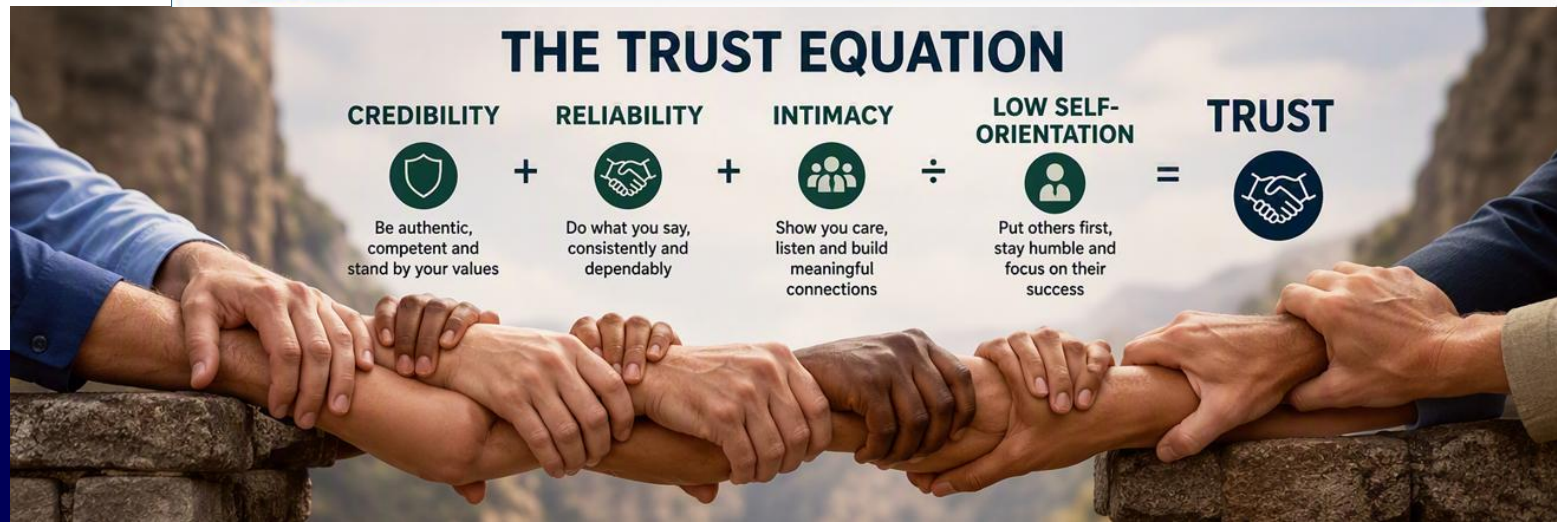
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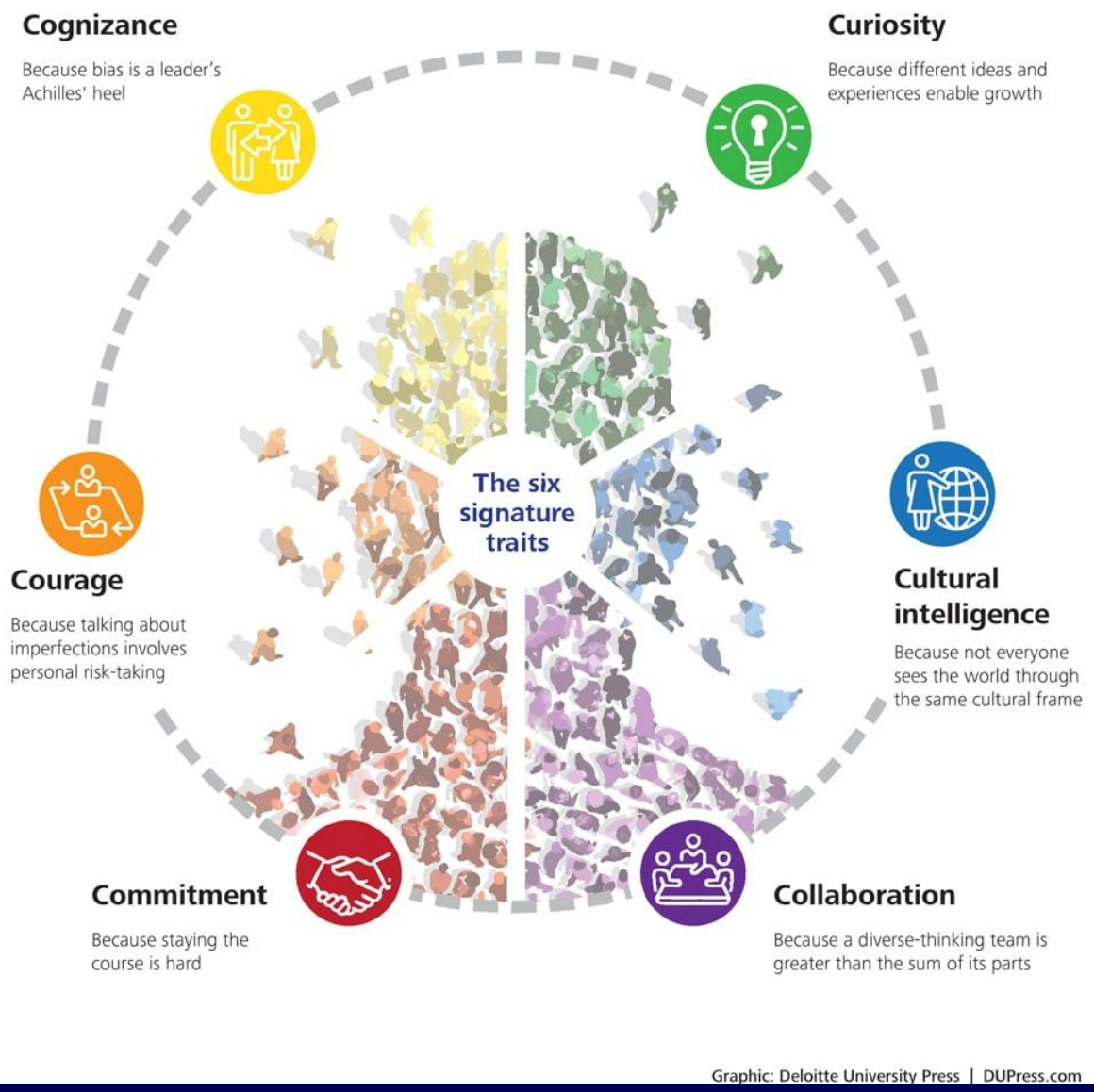
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PART 5: Inclusive Leadership

Inclusive Leadership

"Inclusive leaders create environments where people feel they belong and where their uniqueness is valued."

6 Signature Traits of An Inclusive Leader



Inclusive Leadership

Managing Diverse Perspectives *- Harnessing cognitive diversity through inclusive leadership behaviours*

Cognizance of Bias *(The Foundation)*	Curiosity *(The Catalyst)*	Collaboration *(The Environment)*
• **Check the Mirror:** Actively identify your own blind spots to prevent favouritism. • **Build Fair Processes:** Set structured, data-driven rules so every voice gets an objective hearing.	• **Listen to Learn:** Practice active listening instead of listening just to reply or judge. • **Seek Friction:** Comfortably sit with ambiguity and welcome respectful pushback.	• **Ensure Psychological Safety:** Create a culture where people can speak up without fear of negative consequences. • **Design for Diversity:** Purposely mix team composition to break down silos and cliquey subgroups.

Inclusive Leadership

Communication Across Different Work Styles *- Adapting leadership behaviors to connect, align, and empower every individual.*



Cultural Intelligence

Flex Your Approach: Learn how your team members prefer to receive information (e.g., direct vs. indirect, written vs. verbal).

Check Assumptions: Recognize that your own communication style is not the "default" or only right way to work.



Courage

Invite Vulnerability: Model deep humility by admitting when you don't have all the answers, opening the door for others to speak up.

Address Misalignment: Gently but directly address communication friction before it turns into conflict.



Commitment

Set Clear Team Norms: Establish collective rules for meetings, deadlines, and updates to accommodate different paces.

Unify the Group: Focus on shared, common goals to prevent the team from fracturing into communication silos.

PART 6: Application

Application Activity

Case Study: The Silent Team

Linh was recently promoted to lead a product development team. The team consists of experienced employees from different departments who have worked together for nearly two years. Although the team is technically strong, several issues have emerged:

- **Team members rarely challenge ideas during meetings.**
- **Most discussions are dominated by two senior employees.**
- **Several mistakes have only been identified at the last minute.**
- **Employees often discuss concerns privately after meetings rather than raising them openly.**
- **Newer team members contribute very little.**
- **One team member recently told HR: "It is easier to remain quiet than risk saying the wrong thing."**

Linh is frustrated because she believes he has created an open environment. He frequently asks: "Does anyone have any questions or concerns?" Yet the team remains unusually quiet. The organisation expects the team to deliver a major new product within six months.

Group Task:

Assume you are Linh's leadership team. Using the concepts from today's session and discuss the following questions:

- What warning signs suggest that trust may be low within this team? Identify at least three.
- Using Amy Edmondson's framework, which zone is this team likely operating in? Apathy; Anxiety; Comfort; Learning Zone. Why?
- Which TRUST behaviour requires the most immediate attention? Transparency; Reliability; Understanding; Safety; Team First. Explain your reasoning.
- Looking at the Trust Equation, which component appears weakest? Credibility; Reliability; Intimacy; Self-Orientation. Why?
- If you were Linh, what three specific actions would you take in the next 30 days?

Personal Leadership Commitment

What are behaviours I will STOP/START/CONTINUE doing?

STOP	START	SUSTAIN/CONTINUE

E.g.
I will stop relying on the same 2–3 "go-to" people for quick feedback during projects.

I will stop interrupting or filling silent gaps in meetings, giving internal processors time to speak up.

E.g.
I will start sending meeting agendas and pre-work 24 hours in advance to equalize the playing field.

I will start asking open-ended questions like, "What am I missing here?" or "Who has a completely different view?"

E.g.
I will continue meeting my staff individually once a month.

I will continue encouraging respectful discussion and differing viewpoints within my team.



Final Thoughts

"*Trust is the glue of life. It is the foundational principle that holds all relationships*." – Stephen M.R. Covey

"*Psychological safety is not about being nice*." – Amy Edmondson

"*Trust is earned in droplets and lost in buckets*." – David Maister

"*A team is not a group of people who work together. A team is a group of people who trust each other*." – Simon Sinek

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Thank you!

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